



Turning Public Records into Local Knowledge and Civic Infrastructure

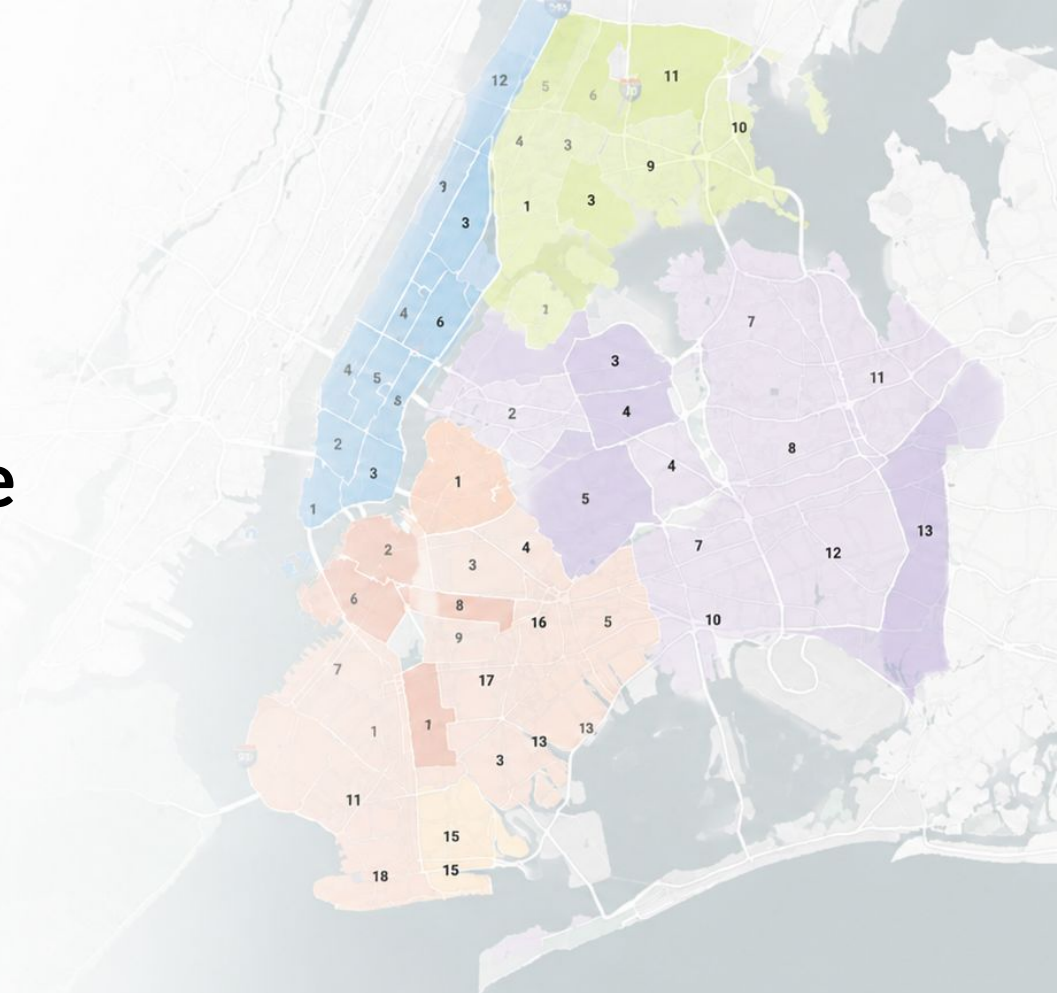
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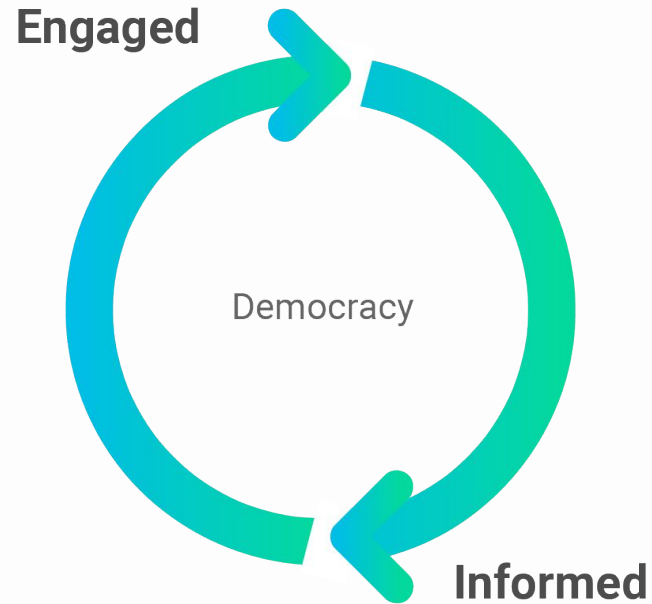
Data Scientist, NYCuriosity Author &
Manhattan CB3 Member

Amy X. Chen

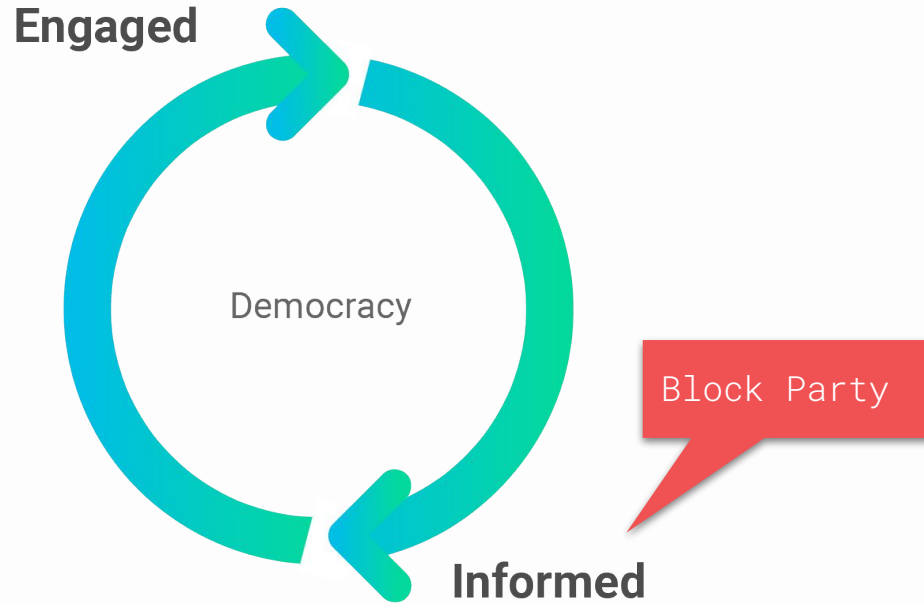
Master in Urban Planning Candidate at Harvard GSD &
Block Party Intern

Harvard — The Responsive Cities Network
September 2026





How might technology be used to help make local democracy more accessible?



How might technology be used to help make local democracy more accessible?

**What civic knowledge is your city generating...
and what happens to it?**

In NYC, we have Community Boards!

Why are Community Boards important?

local Stakeholders,
Policy,
Participation,
Decisions...

Community Boards produce more unstructured civic data than almost any other level of government.

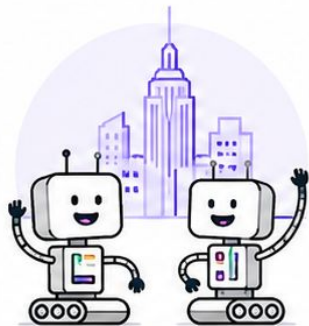
Community Board Meetings can be inaccessible.

Community Board meetings on average last

02:00:00

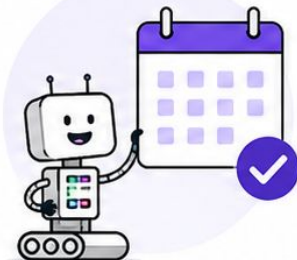
The longest Community Board meeting in our Archive lasted

07:22:17



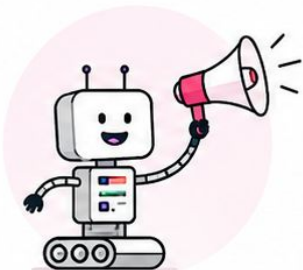
59 community boards

Across NYC's five boroughs



Monthly public meetings

Full board and committee meetings create a public record of local concerns



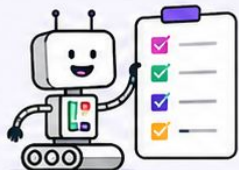
Advisory, but influential

Boards issue recommendations on land use, licensing, budget priorities, and neighborhood needs



Local issues, local knowledge

Transportation • housing • parks • public safety • land use • quality of life



Community Boards are where neighborhood priorities become public records.

Local voices. Public process. Lasting impact.

What Is a Resolution?

Resolutions are official, written, public positions on a local issue.

Standard resolution format:

TITLE: **One-sentence summary**

WHEREAS, [context and reasoning]...

WHEREAS, [additional context]...

THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED,
that Community Board 3 [action]...

Community Boards vote on:

- Bar & restaurant liquor licenses
- Traffic safety improvements
- Real estate developments
- City agency requests
(repaving, tree planting...)
- City-wide policy positions

Agenda



Part 1: The Problem & Opportunity

Part 2: Our Solution & Workflow

Part 3: Demo

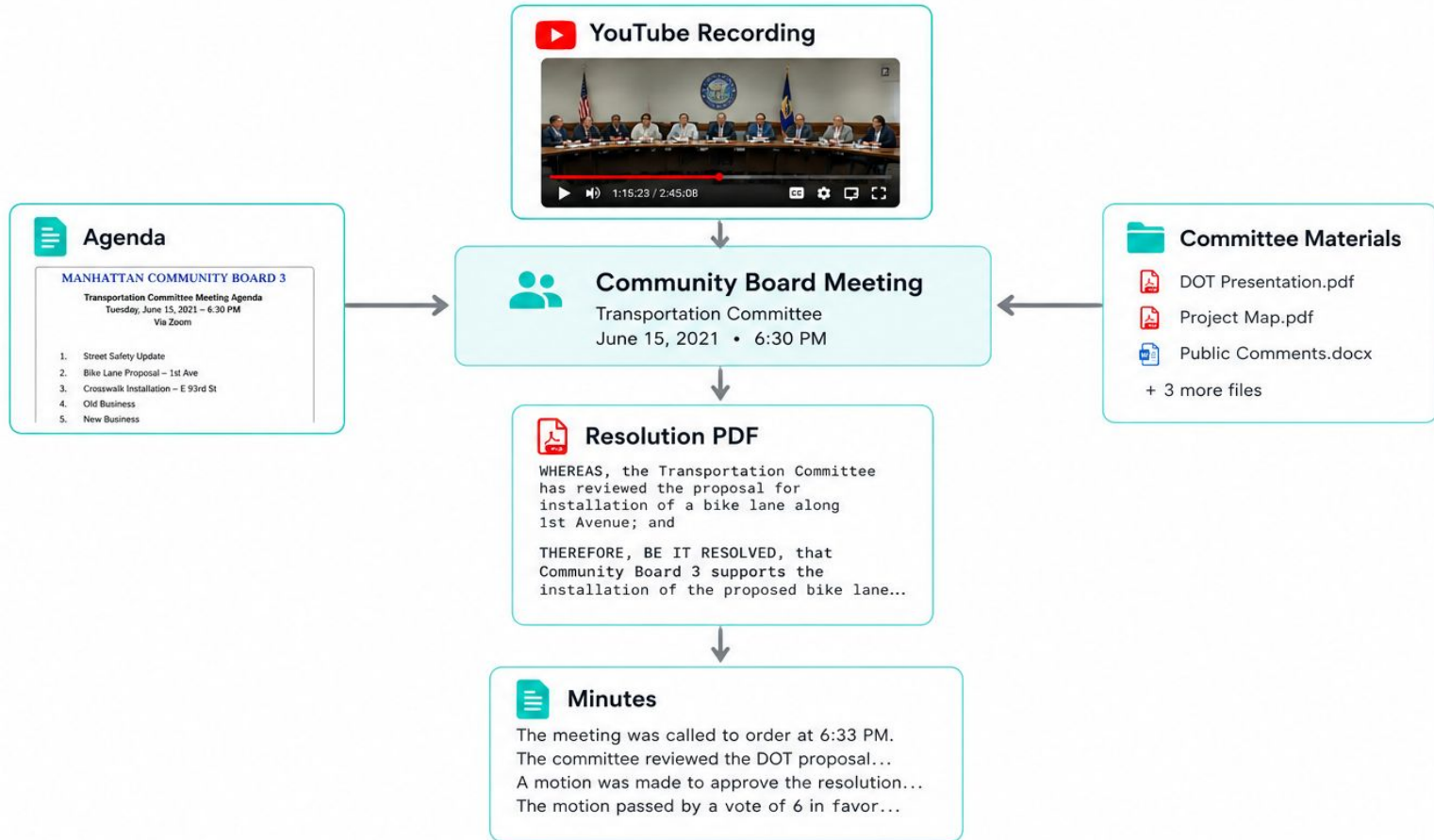
Q&A

The Problem & Opportunity



- The Information Problem
- What is a Resolution
- The Technology Opportunity

The Information Problem



The Information Problem

Community boards are officially transparent — but practically opaque.

✓ What exists

- All meetings open to the public
- All resolutions and votes recorded publicly
- Minutes posted as PDFs or on Airtable on individual community board websites
- Documents go back to early 2000s

✗ What's missing

- No structured database
- No search across resolutions
- No way to track a topic or location across 20 years of minutes
- Siloed PDFs, Word documents, or HTML pages with no consistent formatting or file types

Term Limits Are Coming

<u>Earliest Full-Term Appointment or Reappointment Date On Or After April 1, 2019</u>	<u>Latest Possible Expiration Date Assuming Maximum Reappointments and Continuous Service</u>
April 1, 2019	March 31, 2027
April 1, 2020	March 31, 2030
April 1, 2021	March 31, 2029
April 1, 2022	March 31, 2030
April 1, 2023	March 31, 2031
April 1, 2024	March 31, 2032

Table from the Office of the Manhattan Borough President

Community Board member term limits begin in 2027 - is local government prepared for the significant loss of institutional knowledge?

This is a problem Block Party can help solve.

When Local Decisions Become Usable Data

Find



Search years of decisions by issue, place, organization, or topic.

Connect



Follow an issue across meetings, neighborhoods, and time.

Understand



Recover the context, tradeoffs, and next steps behind a decision.



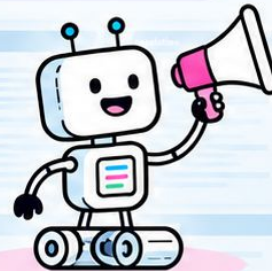
From individual records



to a history of an issue

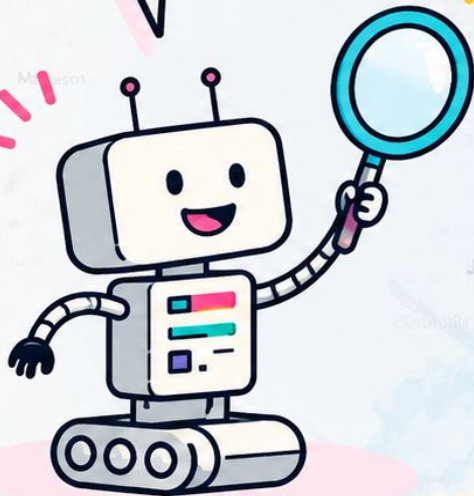


to local context



What does this look like for a real neighborhood issue?

What does this look like for a real neighborhood issue?


[Meetings](#)
[Resolutions](#)

SEARCH RESOLUTIONS

FILTER BY DATE RANGE

Select month range...

BOROUGH

Select

COMMUNITY BOARD

Select

Submit

Reset

Manhattan Community Board 1 Opposes Full Closure of...

 Manhattan Community Board 1
June 2023

Community Board 6 Supports Street Activity Permit for...

 Manhattan Community Board 6
June 2005 Passed
[Home](#)
[Meetings](#)
[Subscribe](#)
[About](#)

Manhattan Community Board 1 Opposes Full Closure of Staple Street for Washington Market School Unless Modified

 Manhattan Community Board 1
June 2023


Resolution summary

CONTEXT

The Washington Market School (WMS) is a non-sectarian, non-profit early childhood center founded in 1976 that provides preschool, kindergarten, and after-school programs in Tribeca at 55 Hudson Street, serving 250 families. WMS applied to the NYC Department of Transportation to renew a Full Closure Open Street permit for Staple Street between Duane and Jay Streets, requesting closure to all vehicles 9:00 AM–6:00 PM, Monday–Friday, year-round. WMS has no outdoor space and began using Staple Street during COVID in 2020; the school now plans to use the street only for special events, not regular recess. Residents and businesses on Staple Street have complained about noise and difficulty accessing their buildings, and neighbors oppose the full closure given that the intersection is already frequently shut down for film industry use on weekends.

ACTION

Oppose the Washington Market School's request for a year-round, full-closure School Open Street permit on Staple Street between Duane and Jay Streets. However, encourage WMS to work with neighbors, the NYC Department of Transportation, and the Street Activity Permit Office to develop an alternative plan that better meets everyone's needs, such as a modified schedule or different DOT program that aligns with the school's limited planned use of the space.

Our Solution & Workflow



- Data Landscape
- How We Built It
- Archival Search and Mapping

PUBLIC RECORDS (Created by Community Boards)



Meeting Recordings
(e.g., YouTube)



Resolution PDFs
(Published on CB websites)

BLOCK PARTY TODAY What Block Party is building now



Generate Transcript
from meeting recording



Searchable Archive
Full transcripts by meeting



2-Minute Meeting Summary
Turn hours of discussion into
a short update so more people
can stay informed and engage.



Extract Structured Information
from Resolution PDFs



Topics



Agencies



Places



Dates



Key Decisions



Resolution Metadata



Resolution Archive
Structured, searchable resolution data

BLOCK PARTY TOMORROW

Where we're headed
next



Searchable Archive
(Transcripts & Summaries)



Resolution Archive
(Structured Resolution Data)



Connected Knowledge
Link records across meetings,
resolutions, committees,
agencies, topics, places,
and time.



Search
Find what you need, fast.



Historical Context
See how issues have evolved.



Maps
Explore data by location.



Trend Analysis
Discover patterns over time.

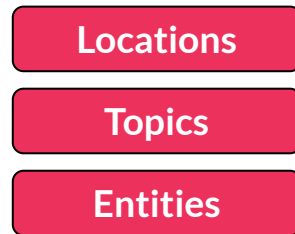
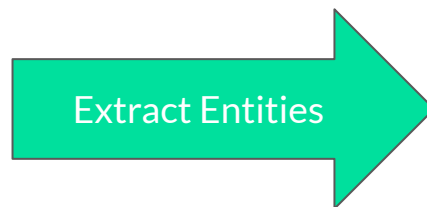
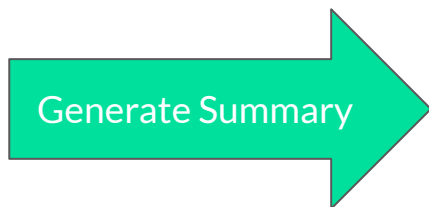
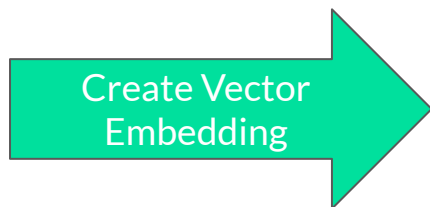
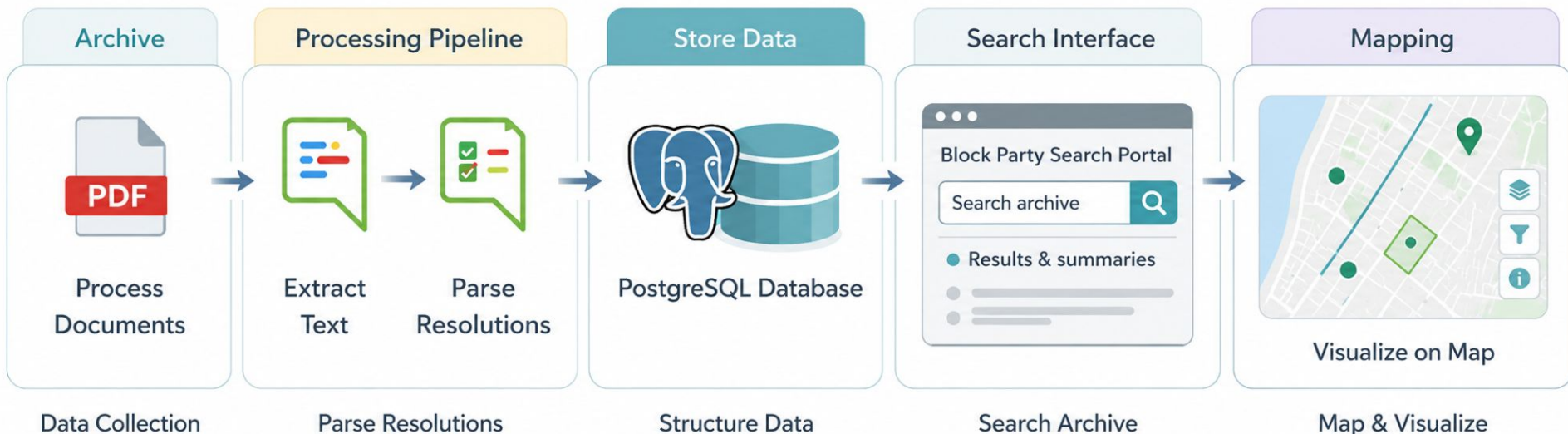


Decision Support
Better information for better decisions.



The Opportunity
Transform fragmented
public records into
connected knowledge
that drives transparency,
engagement, and
better decision-making.

How We Built The Resolutions Archive



Scaling Up

1 DISCOVERY

Find & access sources across the city



NYC Government Assets (nyc.gov)
e.g., MCB3



WordPress Sites
e.g., MCB2, MCB4



Airtable Interfaces
e.g., MCB1



Google Drive Folders
e.g., MCB7



Internet Archive / Wayback (CDX)
e.g., MCB8



Discover & Catalog

Board-specific crawlers, scrapers & connectors

- ✓ URLs & endpoints
- ✓ Schedules
- ✓ Metadata
- ✓ Change detection

2 INGESTION

Normalize documents into clean text



Fetch PDF

Download or retrieve document in memory

- HTTP requests
- Caching
- Rate limiting
- No files saved



Extract Text

Extract text from PDF pages

- pdfplumber
- OCR fallback (scanned PDFs)
- Clean & normalize text



Clean Text

Remove headers, footers, noise & reformat

- Page numbers
- Boilerplate
- Whitespace
- Standardized text

3 PROCESSING

Extract and structure resolutions



Parse Resolutions

Identify resolution blocks and fields

- Title
- Whereas clauses
- Resolved action
- Votes & outcome
- Metadata



Validation & Enrichment

Validate, enrich, and standardize

- Field validation
- Entity extraction
- Summaries
- Consistency checks
- Pydantic validation tests



Quality Gate

Ensure reliability before persistence

- Confidence scoring
- Deduplication
- Manual review (if needed)



High quality, structured resolution data ready for storage and downstream use



Built to Scale



Add new boards via YAML configuration



Incremental updates & change detection



Monitoring, logging & error handling



One pipeline, many sources

2. Recommendations for Canal Street redesign
VOTE: TITLE: Support for NYC DOT's "Reimaging Canal

WHEREAS, the NYC Department of Transportation Street redesign proposal, which aims to address space challenges along Canal Street from West St

WHEREAS, Manhattan Community Board 1, Manhattan Community Board 3 (CB3) have participated in DC Canal Street redesign proposal presented in late 2

WHEREAS, DOT data shows that Canal Street experiences cyclists, and vehicles, with both AM and PM mode walking and transit, highlighting the need for safe and

WHEREAS, from 2020–2024 Canal Street experienced including 34 pedestrian injuries (4 severe, 2 fatal) pedestrian injuries (1 severe, 1 fatality) on the west Street is a high-injury corridor requiring urgent sa

WHEREAS, the redesign proposal responds to the

- full-block sidewalk extensions to reduce crowding
- new marked crosswalks, painted curb extensions shorten crossings and improve pedestrian safety
- protected bike-lane connections to close major
- simplified intersections through realigned cross
- improved curb management including simplified areas on side streets, designated passenger-lo

WHEREAS, DOT's merchant survey conducted in 2018 businesses receive deliveries between 9–11 AM, and own delivery times, meaning businesses cannot c

WHEREAS, DOT has committed to updating this n

WHEREAS, DOT has reduced the speed limits of a part of the Lower Manhattan Regional Slow Zone

WHEREAS, the New York City Department of Transportation Global Corridor, a designation used in NYC DOT's Guidelines to describe streets with exceptionally high destination density, and complex, multidirectional

WHEREAS, for Global Corridors, NYC DOT's design sidewalks than typical streets in order to safely accommodate demand, including an overall sidewalk width of at

clear walking paths, furnishing zones, and space for street trees and amenities, where feasible;

WHEREAS, the proposed project timeline anticipates Phase 1 implementation beginning in July 2026, following continued engagement with Community Boards, elected officials, schools, small businesses, and other stakeholders through spring

WHEREAS, that New York City Department of Transportation primary community concerns raised during outreach, include

- Illegal vending on sidewalks and the lack of consistent
- Use of sidewalks for display by shop owners, as well as
- Need for drop-off and pick-up points given the large providers, medical offices and specialized clinics also
- Loss of street space on Canal Street necessary for local businesses located on Canal Street;
- Relocating loading zones to side streets, especially where permitted or the streets are already narrow needs to
- Placard parking abuses and possibility of additional open/public spaces;
- Projected congestion on narrow streets, such as Bax construction of the Manhattan Detention Center and reconstruction of 80 Mulberry Street;
- Comprehensive traffic study to also include the expense related to the construction of the Manhattan Detention
- More recent and extensive outreach to the local business corridor; and

WHEREAS, that New York City Department of Transportation community support for the goals to address longstanding challenges along Canal Street and the redesign plan for CB3;

THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED that CB3 strongly supports New York City Department of Transportation's Canal Street redesign while noting that the proposal currently lacks a complete unloading, and street vending, and requests that such a following feedback; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that CB3 urges the New York City work with relevant City agencies to advance a coordinated compliance framework for legal vending along Canal Street paths, accessibility, and orderly curbside activity, including

- 1) NYC DOT is urged to coordinate interagency efforts to curbside organization, clear delineation of pedestrian measures that reduce conflicts between pedestrians
- 2) The Department of Consumer and Worker Protection vending licensing and permitting requirements and enforcement and compliance pathways to support lawful vending
- 3) The New York City Police Department (NYPD) is urged to enforce safety, and quality-of-life regulations, as appropriate agencies;
- 4) The Department of Sanitation (DSNY) is urged to act including the obstruction of sidewalks;
- 5) All relevant City agencies are urged to ensure that education and outreach to promote compliance, such as conflicts with pedestrians, residents, and local business

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that CB3 urges NYC DOT to act with an emphasis on providing for pedestrian safety and accessibility residents and the operational needs for local businesses and institutions, including the following:

- 1) Reducing pedestrian crossing distances across Canal Street through the use of protected curb extensions (bulb-outs), reduced travel lane widths, and include median pedestrian refuge areas where feasible;

- 2) Improving intersection safety through the review and adjustment of traffic signal timing and the installation of Leading Pedestrian Intervals (LPIs) where appropriate;
- 3) Reallocating street space by removing the existing rush-hour travel lane on Canal Street and prioritizing pedestrian space and organized curbside uses in support of local residents, businesses, and institutions, including:
 - a. Designated commercial and neighborhood loading and unloading zones with accommodations for micromobility uses;
- 4) Reduce sidewalk congestion by providing areas within an expanded sidewalk to support orderly and legal vending activity while minimizing conflicts with pedestrian movement;
- 5) Supporting the closure of Walker Street between Baxter Street and Canal Street to expand pedestrian space around the Chinatown kiosk, and urging NYC DOT to address community concerns of placard abuse through the installation of physical barriers to prevent vehicle access; and
- 6) Exploring new opportunities with the expanded pedestrian spaces for green infrastructure elements such as street trees, planters, and stormwater features to deliver environmental and public-health benefits, including improved air quality, urban heat island mitigation, stormwater management, and enhanced pedestrian comfort;

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that NYC DOT include CB3 on any block by block community outreach;

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that CB3 may have additional requests due to any potential negative health impacts or impacts to emergency vehicle access. CB3 requests that NYC DOT return to CB3 to present a refined plan incorporating this feedback prior to implementation.

Discussion: anything regarding emergency vehicles? Anything regarding Manhattan Bridge?

Motion to vote: to add "CB3 may have additional requests due to any potential negative health impacts or impacts to emergency vehicle access."

Resolutions as a Data Source

Community Board 3 backs NYC DOT's 'Reimagining Canal Street' redesign while urging detailed vending, loading, and operational plans

Manhattan Community Board 3

January 2026

[View Meeting PDF](#)

Reliable data points

Resolution Summary

CONTEXT

Canal Street is a high-injury, high-pedestrian-volume corridor—DOT data and 2020–2024 crash records show numerous pedestrian injuries and fatalities—creating long-standing safety, mobility, and curbside management challenges for residents, businesses, and transit users. DOT's redesign proposes wider sidewalks, protected bike lanes, curb extensions, and other pedestrian improvements with Phase 1 targeted for July 2026, but local merchants and stakeholders have raised concerns about deliveries, street vending, curb management, and potential impacts on emergency access.

Community concerns

ACTION

CB3 voted to strongly support the project's safety goals while demanding DOT produce a comprehensive plan for loading/unloading and legal vending, coordinate enforcement and operations with DCWP, NYPD, and DSNY, implement pedestrian safety measures (e.g., curb extensions, LPIs, lane reallocation, designated loading zones), include CB3 in block-by-block outreach, and return with a refined plan prior to implementation, reserving the right to raise additional requests related to health impacts or emergency vehicle access.

[Show Full Resolution Text](#)

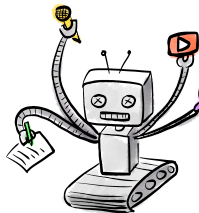
Next steps

Locations

Entities

Topics

Resolutions as a Data Source



What if we could map the locations mentioned?

Community Board 3 backs NYC DOT's 'R' detailed vending, loading, and operation

Manhattan Community Board 3

January 2026

[View Meeting PDF](#)

Resolution Summary

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[Show Full Resolution Text](#)

Reliable data points

Community concerns

Next steps

Locations

Entities

Topics

Mapping Resolutions



EXAMPLE: EXTRACT PLACE FROM RESOLUTION



Resolution Text (Input)

"...install a bike lane
along **Canal Street**
from **Broadway** to
Chatham Square..."



Extracted Place Information (Output)



Place Name (Original): Canal Street



Place Type: Segment / Corridor



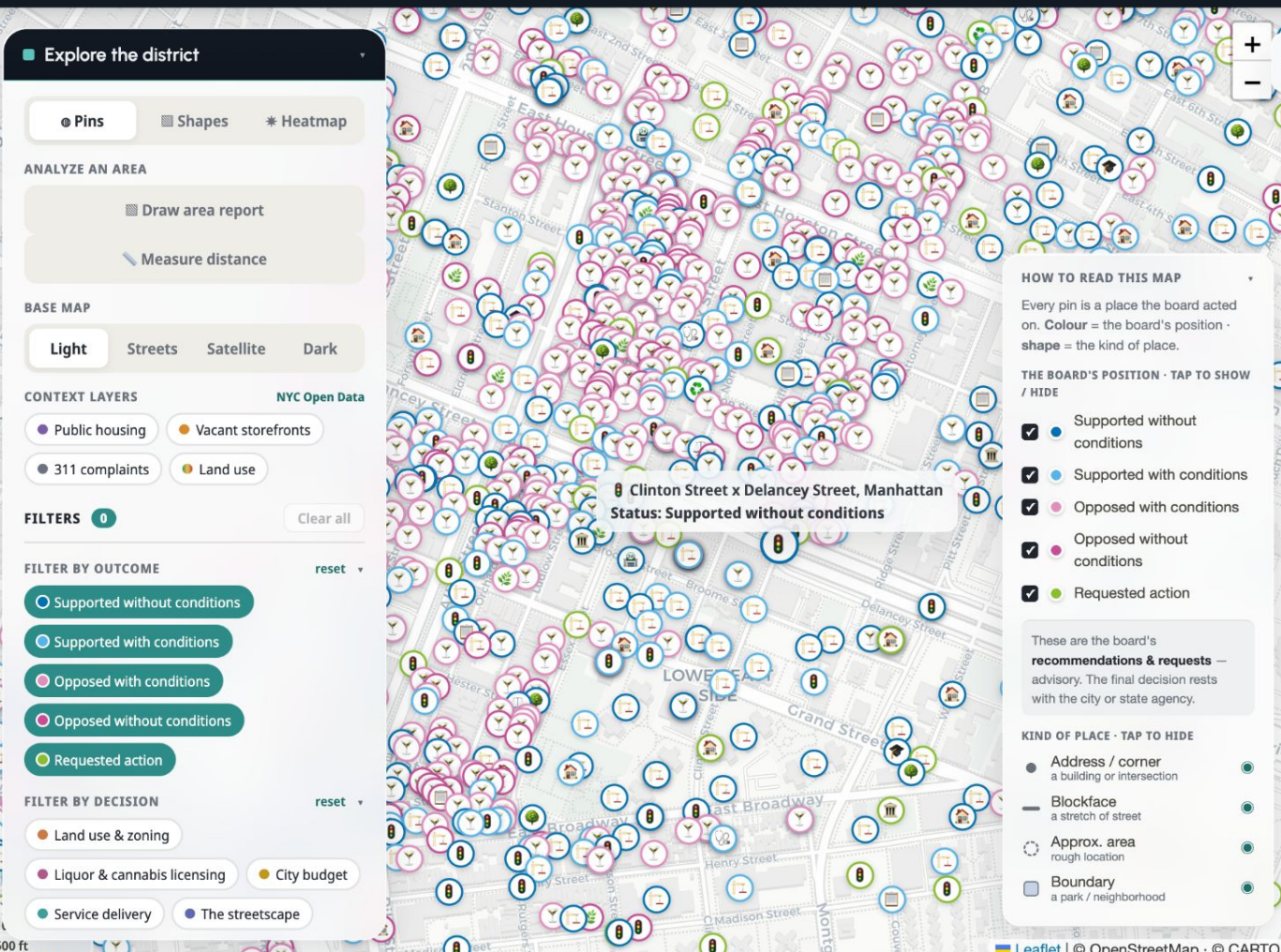
Start Location: Broadway



End Location: Chatham Square



Geometry (Result): LINESTRING



Engage with the decisions shaping your block

New York City has **59 community boards** — local, appointed bodies that advise on land use, liquor licenses, street changes and neighborhood budget priorities. Their meetings are **public**, but often held during work hours and unpaid to attend — so not everyone has the time or energy to keep up with local politics or make their voice heard.

Block Party bridges that gap by restructuring how civic information flows. It reads the meeting record, extracts every place a board acted on, and maps it — so residents, businesses, and officials can understand the *reasons and experiences* behind the decisions shaping their neighborhood. You're currently exploring **Manhattan Community Board 3**.

► **Take a guided tour** — see it through one lens

Resident Board member Planner

Researcher City agency Bar / business

♦ All features (30s)

Replay intro

Get involved with your board

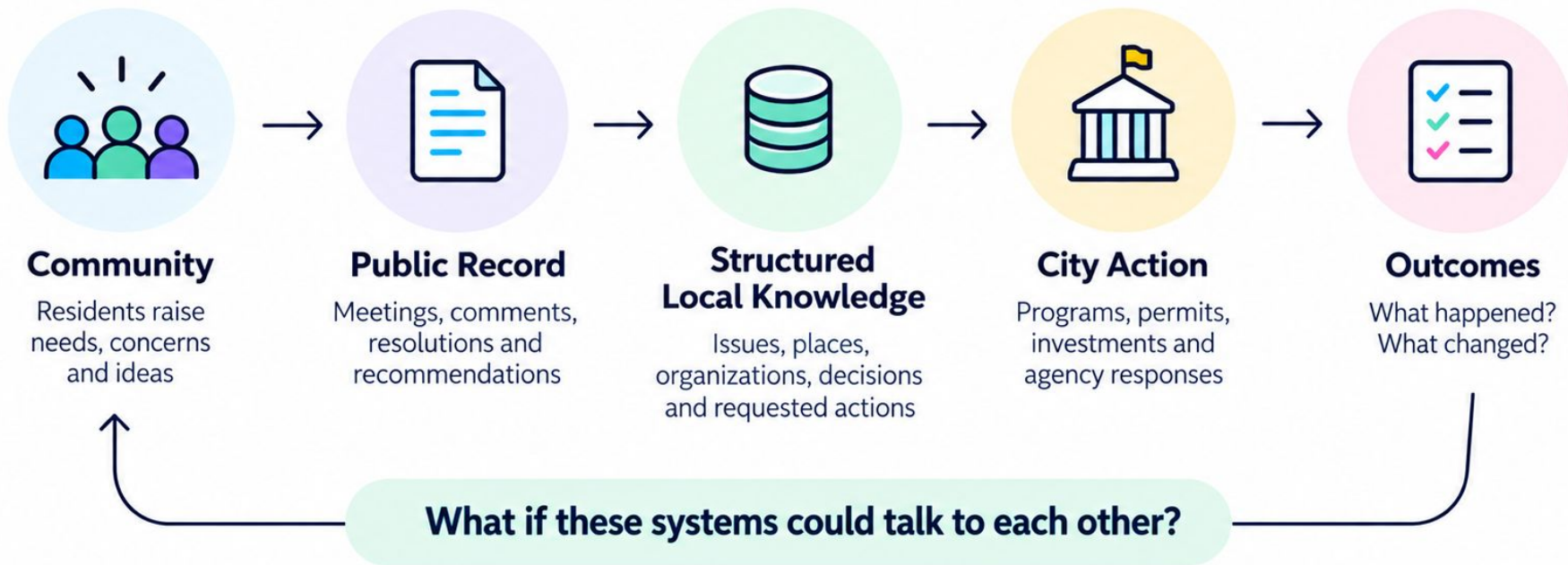
This map shows what the board *decided*. Here's how to shape what's next:

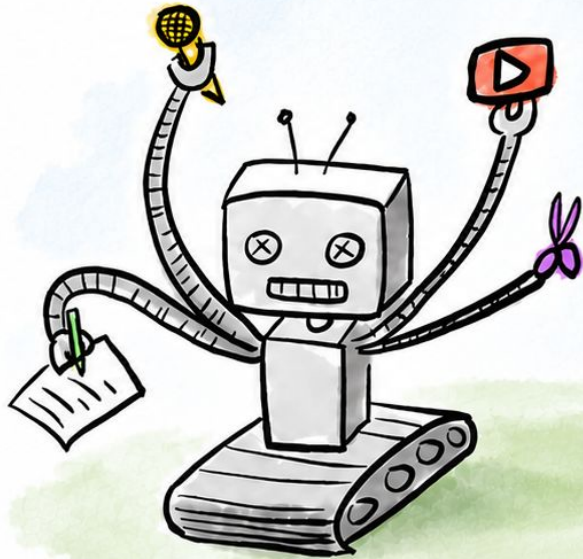
CB3 — meetings, members & minutes

Demo Time!



From Community Input to City Action





block party

blockparty.studio

blockparty.meeting@gmail.com

nycuriosity.com



Appendix

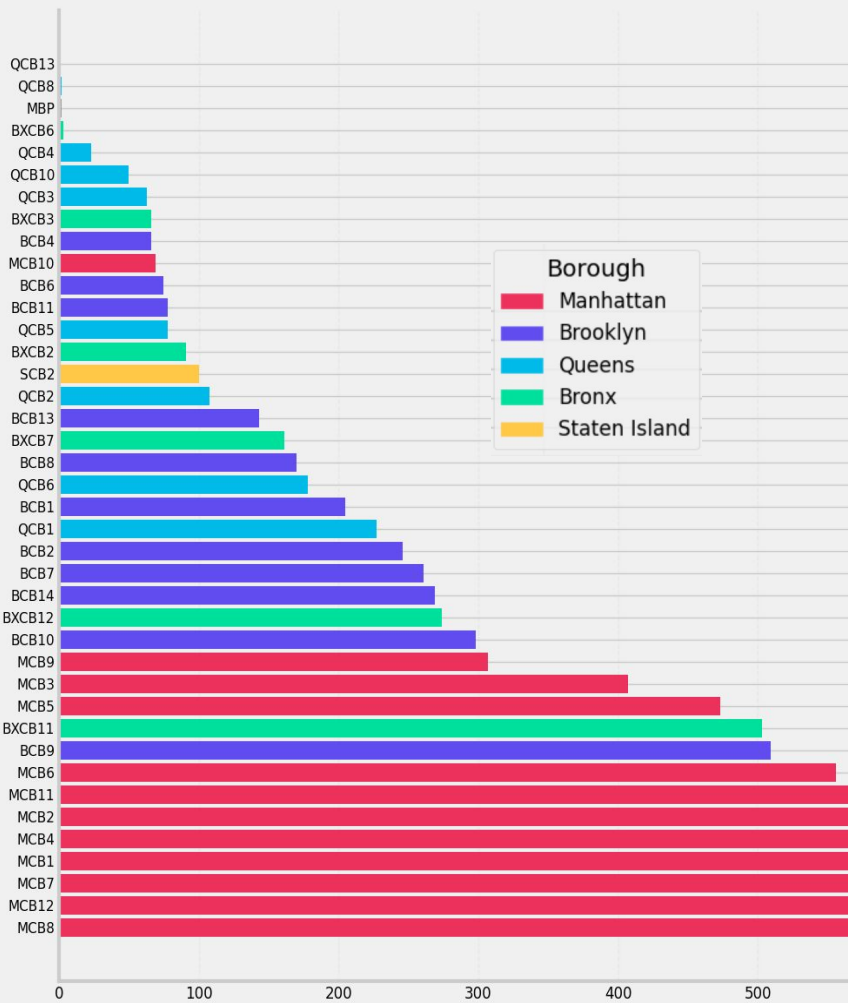
City	Closest local body	Geographic / neighborhood-based?	Central city governance & standards	Similarity to NYC CBs
NYC	59 Community Boards	✓ Yes — defined districts	High — common structure established by City Charter, standardized roles/processes	Baseline
St. Paul (MN)	17 District Councils	✓ Yes — defined districts	Med-High — independent nonprofits, but city-funded through a common program, annual city contracts and required procedures	High (Saint Paul Minnesota)
Philadelphia	Registered Community Organizations (RCOs)	✓ Often neighborhood-based; boundaries can overlap	Medium — organizations are independent but formally registered/recognized through a city framework	Med-High (City of Philadelphia)
Detroit	Community Advisory Councils	✓ Council-district based	Medium — formal district-level mechanism, but not uniformly operating citywide	Med-High
San José	Neighborhood Associations + Boards/Commissions	⚠ Associations cover local geographies, but not one standardized district system	Low-Medium for neighborhood groups; High for formal commissions	Medium-Low — more fragmented than NYC (City of San Jose)
West Palm Beach	Neighborhood Associations	✓ Neighborhood-based	Low — explicitly self-administered, not city-mandated, with their own bylaws	Medium-Low (WPCB GIS Portal)
Charlotte	Boards & Commissions	✗ Mostly issue/function-based	High — centrally administered appointments, policies and procedures	Low — standardized, but not neighborhood governance (Charlotte NC)
Long Beach	Boards, Commissions & Committees	✗ Mostly issue/function-based	High — formal city advisory bodies	Low
Lexington	Boards & Commissions + neighborhood associations	⚠ Mixed	Mixed — formal boards centralized; neighborhood groups more decentralized	Low
Columbia	Boards & Commissions + neighborhood organizations	⚠ Mixed	Mixed — formal boards centralized; neighborhood organizations more decentralized	Low
Boulder	Boards & Commissions	✗ Mostly issue/function-based	High — formal city advisory structure	Low

Meeting Transcripts by Community Board



Cumulative Number of Community Board Transcripts

Community Board



Total Number of Meeting Transcripts

Number of Transcripts

10000

8000

6000

4000

2000

0

2016

2017

2018

2019

2020

2021

2022

2023

2024

2025

2026

Year

As our Archive of transcript data grew over the years, Block Party continued to evolve



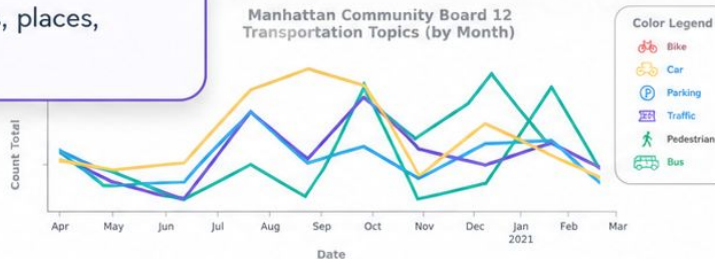
Connected Knowledge

Link records across meetings, resolutions, committees, agencies, topics, places, and time.

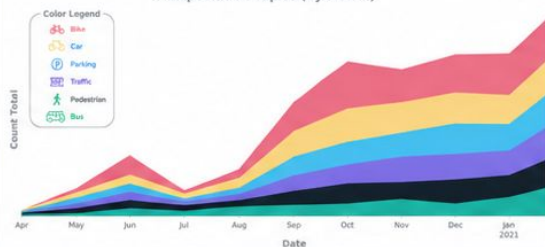


block party

Manhattan Community Board 12
Transportation Topics (by Month)



Transportation Topics (by Month)



Block Party Transcript Text Analysis



Total: 315 Meetings Mention: "Resilient"



Resolution

Canal Street Redesign Resolution

Topic: Transportation

Place: Canal Street

Agency: NYC DOT

Decision: Support with requests



Transcript Context

⌚ 2 min read

"Our main concern is that, all parking spaces on **Canal Street** from **Broadway** to **East Elizabeth Street** will be removed under the new DOT plan to widen the sidewalks. This will create major problems for truck delivery to local businesses and for seniors and patients with mobility impairments, who rely on ambulance or call service to reach the doctor's offices. Especially, since there are about 200 medical providers and two large radiology center on **Canal Street**."



The resolution tells us what happened. The transcript helps explain why.

